

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

THE SILENCE STRATEGY

Opposition leader Rahul Gandhi called it a 'weapon for marginalising Muslims' on social media, but when the Lok Sabha was actually debating the Waqf (Amendment) Bill, he was nowhere to be found. Both Rahul and sister and Wayanad MP Priyanka Vadra—reportedly in the US tending to an ailing relative—were absent during discussions on President's rule in Manipur too, with the former departing after the Waqf Bill vote. Sources say advisors may have cautioned the Gandhis against engaging on the Waqf issue to prevent "alienating the Hindus" against the Congress. The silence also aligns with Rahul's directive to party MPs about wider parliamentary participation and rotating speaking opportunities instead of the same faces taking on every issue.

JEERS AND FEARS



When poetry meets empty pockets, apparently no metaphor is compelling enough. An outreach event in Kolkata on April 7—meant to assuage the schoolteachers rendered jobless by the Supreme Court in the recruitment scam verdict—achieved exactly the opposite. On the stage, author Abul Bashar and poet Subodh Sarkar offered platitudes of how CM **Mamata Banerjee** "will take care of you", but were drowned out by the jeers. Even Mamata, seated silently on the dais throughout, was rudely interrupted twice by the angry protesters when she got up to speak, while education minister Bratya Basu and chief secretary Manoj Pant looked on, visibly uncomfortable.

Bargaining Chips

New Congress Bihar in-charge **Krishna Allavaru** took charge on Valentine's Day, but got little love from ally RJD. They couldn't be blamed—then Congress state unit chief Akhilesh Singh, an erstwhile RJD enthusiast, was suddenly dissing party patriarch Lalu Prasad, while young turk Kanhaiya Kumar was grabbing too much attention with his Bihar *padayatra*. Congress sources says the moves only signalled the party's *aatmanirbharta* before the seat-sharing talks with the hard-bargaining RJD. The peace offering came on April 5—Allavaru met Lalu in Delhi while new Congress state chief Rajesh Ram called on his son and RJD chief Tejashwi—perfectly timed for Rahul Gandhi's April 7 visit to Bihar.



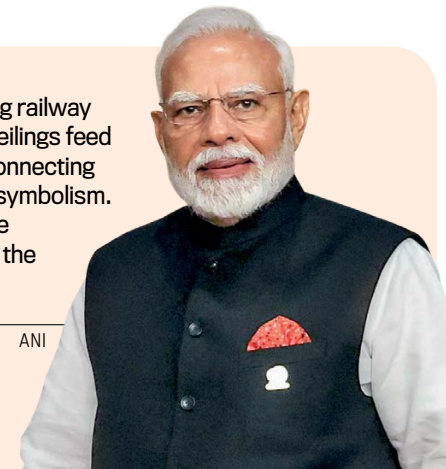


POLITICAL POPCORN

After PM Modi and former PM Atal Bihari Vajpayee, another BJP stalwart is stepping into the cinematic spotlight. *Ajey: The Untold Story of a Yogi* will chart the rapid political ascent of Uttar Pradesh CM **Yogi Adityanath**, with *12th Fail* and *Yeh Kaali Kaali Ankhein* actor Anant Joshi portraying the saffron-clad leader. Former BJP MP Paresh Rawal also stars in the film. The biopic boom doesn't stop there—*The Kerala Story* director Sudipto Sen is now turning producer for a film on India's first tribal president, Droupadi Murmu. Politics is clearly the new popcorn.

Bridge the Gap

Fresh off the inauguration of the new Pamban Bridge in Tamil Nadu, Prime Minister Narendra Modi is now expected to open the final stretch of the Udhampur-Srinagar-Baramulla Rail Link in Jammu & Kashmir—India's most challenging railway project yet. The back-to-back unveilings feed into the BJP's 'One Nation' pitch, connecting distant corners through steel and symbolism. From Rameswaram to Kashmir, the message is clear: infrastructure is the new bridge of unity.



ANI

Kaushik Deka with Arkamoy Datta Majumdar, Amitabh Srivastava, Suhani Singh and Avishek G. Dastidar